

than in the P.M. Some places offer outrageous deals and specials to fill seats during the midday dead zone. Bonus: you'll get to see what your date looks like in the cold hard light of day.

6. **Dinner and a movie—with a twist.** There's something to be said for keeping with tradition; no harm in following a tried-and-true formula. But forgo the \$18-per-ticket summer blockbuster and pick up a movie at your local library instead (free if you're a patron). Or download a film online for \$2.99 and cuddle up with your honey at home. If you're gifted with culinary prowess, make dinner yourself. Bonus: since you're playing host or hostess, you might get to relax by kicking off more than your shoes.
7. **Find a meetup group.** Meetup.com was started by a couple of guys in New York City in the wake of the September 11 attacks. They wanted to make it easier for people to connect with strangers in their community. Now Meetup is flourishing, with groups and events in hundreds of cities. You can create a profile at no cost and then search for groups by common interests—everything from photography to squash to investing to ikebana. Most events are free. What's great about Meetup is that you are introduced to a group of potential partners who share at least one of your interests. Bonus: by meeting people in a large social setting, you'll alleviate the high pressure (and high cost) of a first date.
8. **Online dating version 2.0.** According to *The Globe and Mail*, Canada is a hotbed for online dating. If you're dead set on keeping up with the trends, nothing I say is going to dissuade you. At the very least, try your luck on some of the free dating sites before doling out hefty membership fees. Sites like Plentyoffish.com, launched in 2003 out of an apartment in British Columbia, are giving the big corporate sites a run